POSTED to EE&T ALUMNI
12 MAR 2026

Sections: -- International Women’s Day -- Craftsmanship -- Unix in ElecEng -- Bell Labs & Unix

== INTRODUCTION ==

A creative, a crafty and a collaborative post aligned with International Women's Day.
[Spoiler]: Ken Thompson had enough time to code while his wife was visiting her relatives.
[1st comment]: Enjoyed YT clips about Unix.

== INTERNATIONAL WOMEN’S DAY ==

Hopefully, last Sunday's acknowledgement went well. Don't forget the creative, the supportive and the nurturing awareness doesn't end when it's over. Reminders and acknowledgements from time to time help too.

== CRAFTSMANSHIP ==

Similar lived experience?

*) Craftsmanship leads leads to joy and beauty.
*) The world needs more people who are proud of what they make.

*) Cognitive skills develop quickly.
*) Learn to rest when you're stuck instead of burning out.

*) Remembering why you started can help you reset. (Bell Labs in IEEE article).
*) Nothing like a job well done.

== UNIX in ElecEng ==

When you passed John Lions in the corridors of the early 1980's, you could tell behind the nod & smile that his mind was always working on a problem.

He documented ElecEng's uncopyrighted Level-VI version of Unix, the mainframe operating system. His book was instantly popular.

When Bell Labs realised its success, the improved Level-VII version included a copyright that prevented sharing it outside the Universities.

ElecEng ran the Level-VII software. We learned Pascal, C and Shell scripts. Some local CompSci students like Brian Palmer, Perry Brown, Stephen Fraser, Russell Robinson improved a few features along the way. Fun times at the terminals . . .

The PDP-11/70 names were 'Elec70a' and 'Elec70b'. Jeff Skebe in the Digital Systems Lab (DSL) accepted the 'moved-on' PDP-11/34.

In 1991, the Computing Department moved out of ElecEng and formed its own School behind MechEng (Ainsworth). As of Nov 2025, the first floor museum had John Lions' book in the showcase under the Honour Board. English and Chinese editions. The corridor had the last PDP-11/70 frame with its power supply in the stairwell.

== BELL LABS & UNIX ==

Both Ken Thompson & Brian Kernighan graduated as Electrical Engineers. Ken toyed around with the pushed-aside PDP-7 system in his spare time. He kept the commands and functions simple. He wanted to quickly write and read data on its rotating memory drum.

This IEEE Article seems to reflect what Ken & Brian shared here in the YT clips.

"Strange Birth and Long Life of UNIX"
Warren Toomey, 28 Nov 2011
https://spectrum.ieee.org/the-strange-birth-and-long-life-of-unix

Image credit: lwr rt.

// Posted to EEnT Alumni (LI), Elsoc-Alumni (FB) and own LI space
// 12 MAR 2026
// Ctee: @Kaveh, @Luke, @Edmund, @Shakthi, @Vijay
// Prv Ctee: @GaganSK, @SomanshA, @SimonB, @MatthewR
// Heads: Dean @JulienE; EEnT Prof. @JinhongY
// School: Mgr @ElizabethGT; Projects @KlaraJ

== COMMENT #1 ==

== Enjoyed YT Clips about UNIX ==
// Shortest duration first

Pushing the Limits of Technology The Ken Thompson and Dennis Ritchie Story
National Inventors Hall of Fame - NIHF
3m10
https://youtu.be/g3jOJfrOknA
18 Feb 2019

UNIX was designed for programmers Brian Kernighan and Lex Fridman
Lex Clips
10m06
https://youtu.be/v0ON23Y4W68
22 Jul 2020

The Factory of Ideas Working at Bell Labs - Computerphile
Computerphile
12m31
https://youtu.be/QFK6RG47bww
29 Jul 2015

UNIX memoir, in first person - Ken Thompson
Nerdearla
24m46
https://youtu.be/xKNaCzdn6sY
Sep 25, 2024

VCF East Ken Thompson interviewed by Brian Kernighan
Vintage Computer Federation
1h03m50
https://youtu.be/EY6q5dv_B-o
7 May 2019

VCF East UNIX A History and a Memoir by Brian Kernighan
Vintage Computer Federation
1h10m46
https://youtu.be/WEb_YL1K1Qg
16 Aug 2025

Kenneth Lane Thompson, 1983 ACM Turing Award Recipient
Association for Computing Machinery (ACM)
4h31m27
https://youtu.be/309siTvApbY
Nov 10, 2025

== TOLD BY OTHERS ==

// Shortest duration first

UNIX: The Untold Story
CodeSource
12m08
https://youtu.be/QjdGg2hsNy4
5 Oct 2025

The Rise of Unix. The Seeds of its Fall
Asianometry
16m50
https://youtu.be/HADp3emVABg
2 Jan 2024

The Untold Unix Story
DJ Ware
20m39
https://youtu.be/2oU6zEZafnQ
1 Nov 2022
:
// More background about John Lions' book.
// This chap adds more colour to the stories.

== 7-day View Alumni Response ==
19 MAR so far

Not including the 'untouchable' profiles.

LI (EE&T Alumni)
a) Views = …
b) Emojis = …
c) People = …

LI (Own)
a) Views = …
b) Emojis = …
c) People =
{
…
}

FB (ElsocAlm)
a) Views = not visible by FB
b) Emojis = …
c) People = …
{
…
}